



Netflix as Insta story

Netflix app users can share content artwork to their Instagram Story just by tapping the "share" button. <https://digit.in/feb19-1>



PUBG Subscription

PUBG Mobile will soon get Prime, Prime Plus subscriptions for players to earn more rewards, convert BP to UC. <https://digit.in/feb19-2>

SM or S&M?

If it's so bad, why don't you leave?

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The Cambridge Analytica scandal brought into focus nefarious ways in which data gathered from Facebook and other social media platforms can be used against you. Essentially, marketing campaigns were targeting users with laser focused ads, in an effort to influence elections. Some scaremongering websites went so far as to claim that the data of the users was being 'weaponized'. The #DeleteFacebook campaign started soon after, and we were all for it. We published detailed guides on how to delete yourself from every social media account.

However, I knew all along that reality was much more mundane than what people were thinking. The word "psychographic profiling" conjured up images of a dark cyber magic taking control of your free will, making you do things you wouldn't even dream of! The truth is, you were about to do it anyways and all that 'cyber magic' did was egg you on a little. You think Facebook's the reason you voted as you did or bought that new gadget? Maybe, but researchers from Cambridge can profile you based on just a block of text you've typed, so the only way you're escaping them is by turning off all data services... for good!

Demographic and psychographic profiling has been used for decades by marketers, and it is just a way to sort people into different groups – just makes their jobs easier. Demographic profiling does this based on location, age, gender and so on, while psycho-

graphic profiling does this on your beliefs, habits and ideals. When you buy that environmentally-friendly pair of jeans, congratulations, you've been a "victim" of psychographic profiling. What social media allowed for, was targeting these advertisements to the people who were most likely to react to them, instead of broadcasting it blindly to everyone. It just saves marketers some money, which in turn, should result in you getting a better deal on that gadget you were going to buy anyway.

However, the paranoia is irreversible now, and no one trusts targeted advertising anymore. So what are you waiting for? Rather than complain about it, kill all advertising targeted



at you for good! Most platforms have already showed you how to do it. Facebook and Twitter now also allow you to download the data that they have collected on you, so that you can see it for yourself. You can even delete it all. Not that it matters.

All of your previous activity has probably already been used to build your profile, so deleting it now really doesn't help matters much. A study published in January in Nature Human Behavior titled "Information flow reveals prediction limits in online social activity" shows that the profiling and predictions of human

behaviour can be achieved even after users have deleted their social media profiles. The researchers could predict interests, hobbies, religious commitments, and political affiliations based on the profiles of the friends of users. In principle, the predictions could be made even if you had never signed up for a social media platform in the first place! The only real solution, if privacy is to be guaranteed, is that if everybody stops using social media platforms *en masse*. Might as well hope it rains gold! Instead, you should just say this with me slowly: "Privacy. Is. Dead!"

None of us can afford to be offline anymore. Not once we have tasted the sweetness of the internet. Even if it wasn't for personal use, we'd certainly need to use it for work. That includes social media, because it's a big part of a lot of our work lives. Besides, let's be honest. We want these services. We want relevant results based on the location, interests, and profiling. If not, we'd just get a much worse user experience than everyone else. Don't you want relevant suggestions when watching Netflix? Heck, Netflix actually goes a step further and shows different people different cover artwork!

Of course, there is a good reason to quit social media if you can. Back in 2010 neuroscientists showed that social media interactions increase levels of dopamine. Social media is essentially a drug, and users are all addicts.

[Source: "The Rewarding Nature of Social Interactions", published in *Frontiers in Behavioral Neuroscience*.]

I guess my whinge this month is people who keep whining about social media and what it's doing to them, or how they want to log off, but don't. Like smoking and drugs, the best way to do so is to quit cold turkey. And if you just cannot, at least try and quit it from your handheld device. delete your Facebook, Twitter and Instagram apps right now. You can still access them from a PC (or in Instagram's case, from a tablet that you keep at home). Go on, I double dare you to do it. Can you stop being masochists? Let me know how it goes. 